Game design mentoring

An eight-week syllabus on the Shu-Ha-Ri arc.

Sector: Mentoring and tutoring

Status: concept study, written and designed by Karthik Bindumon, 2026. Numbers are targets or modelled assumptions and are labelled as such.

Method: The Realisation Loop, v1 (see 00-realisation-loop.pdf).

Eight weeks, one to one or groups of up to four. No engine until week five. The student finds the rule; then I name it. I talk for ten minutes an hour, at most.

Arc

Shu (weeks 1 to 3): copy a mechanic exactly, on paper. Ha (weeks 4 to 6): break it on purpose and find out why it held. Ri (weeks 7 to 8): build one nobody has seen and teach hour one to someone else.

Week by week

Week	Session	Exercise	Assessed
1	One button	Design a game with one button; take it away; give it a cost.	Can the student name the feeling, not the mechanic?
2	Paper prototype	Copy a known mechanic with paper and dice. Playtest with a stranger.	Playtest notes: three observations, no opinions.
3	The loop	Name currency, faucet, drain, feedback for the copied game.	One-page loop diagram.
4	Break it	Remove one rule; play again. Why did it hold?	Written explanation of the break.
5	Engine week	Rebuild the paper prototype in an engine, ugly.	Runs. Nothing else.
6	Feel	Tune one number until the game feels different. Log every value.	Tuning log.
7	Ri	Design an original mechanic from a constraint the student picks.	Paper prototype, playtested twice.
8	Teach	Run hour one with a new student. I watch.	The student says the last line before I do.

Reading, one per fortnight

Koster, A Theory of Fun. Caillois, Man, Play and Games (the taxonomy chapters). Csikszentmihalyi, Flow (chapter 4). Gee, What Video Games Have to Teach Us (introduction and chapter 2).

What I do not teach

Engines before loops. Monetisation before feel. Anything the student could have found by playing more.